

Gear — Loop Experience 2 earplugs

What they are. Reusable filtered earplugs (the *Tomorrowland* × *Loop Experience 2* colourway). Unlike foam plugs, they lower the whole sound level fairly **evenly across frequencies** rather than just killing the highs — so music (and your own voice) stays natural, just quieter.

Spec	Value
Attenuation	17 dB SNR (12 dB NRR)
Filter character	Even/low-colouration — keeps sound "crisp," music-focused
Fit	4 silicone tip sizes (XS–L); seal per ear matters
Louder-night option	<i>Experience 2 Plus</i> adds the Loop Mute insert for extra reduction on demand

Owned as of: August 2026 — delivered, in testing.

Why Aaron bought them — hearing protection

Aaron sings/watches at loud karaoke rooms; the Brighton Hotel measures around **105 dB** just standing there (see ``memory/006-brisbane-venues-timezone.md``). At 105 dB, safe unprotected exposure is only minutes. Knocking ~15–17 dB off brings that to roughly **88–90 dB**, where safe exposure is hours — a large cut in dose (every 3 dB roughly halves the sound energy). This alone justifies them.

Real-world caveat: the 17 dB is a lab figure with a perfect seal. Work the tip sizes until each ear gives a clear "sealed" drop; an uneven seal skews the pitch reference between ears.

The open question — do they also help the singing?

Plausibly yes, and for a measured reason. Your own voice reaches your ears partly through **bone conduction**; normally that leaks back out the open ear canal. Plug the canal and it gets trapped — the **occlusion effect** — so with plugs in, your own voice becomes *more* prominent while the band gets quieter. Your voice-to-background ratio improves in the direction you want.

That lands on a known weak point on stage. The Brighton *Kung Fu Fighting* take note reads "backing music was unusually loud and made self-monitoring difficult," and the measured stage habit when you can't hear yourself is to **push** — loud gear early, deeper scoops, support abandoned for volume. Anything that lets you hear yourself against a loud band directly counters that, and pairs with the campaign's one on-stage cue: *one gear in reserve — the mic does the loudness* (``docs/handoffs/COMPETITION_CAMPAIGN_DEC_2026.md``).

Caveats before relying on them

- **Occlusion changes your self-sound** — your voice feels boomier and "inside your head." It won't make you sing flat, but it's a different reference, so there's an adjustment period. Don't debut them cold on a competition stage; wear them at Friday karaoke first.
- **One-ear option** — some singers prefer a single plug in the ear facing the speakers, protection where the blast is, natural hearing on the other side.
- Relates to ``memory/008-headphone-discomfort.md`` (you sing worse with closed headphones at the stand) — earplugs are a lighter, different approach to the same monitoring problem.

The measured test (open)

To turn "feels like it helps" into evidence, record the same song twice at the same loud level — **plugs out** (Take A) then **plugs in** (Take B) — and compare the raw onset measures. The prediction: if hearing yourself better stops you sliding up to find notes, **clean-entry % rises and scoop depth shrinks** in Take B. Home studio is the ideal place to run it (clean capture → trustworthy numbers).

This is logged as forward-dream idea **D10** (the with/without-earplugs A/B one-pager) in `memory/dream-ideas.md`, currently parked.

Status: delivered, in testing — no A/B take recorded yet.

Sources: Loop Experience 2 product spec (au.loopearplugs.com); occlusion effect (standard vocal-pedagogy acoustics); Aaron's Brighton take context, the December competition campaign plan, and the gear/venue memory facts. No scores.